

# Rhetorical Analysis Worksheet

"Giraffe Rescue at Lake Baringo" — Adult Article (National Geographic)

Name: Liam Heary Date: June 2nd, 2026 Period: 0004.su26

## Exigence (Why Now?)

*What is the immediate trigger that prompted this article to be written?*

Immediate trigger: Flooding at Lake Baringo in 2020 trapped endangered Rothschild's giraffes on a rapidly shrinking island, forcing a dangerous rescue.

*What bigger issues create urgency beyond the immediate event?*

Bigger issues: Only 2,000 Rothschild's giraffes remain in the wild; climate-driven flooding is worsening; and decades of human conflict had already nearly wiped the species from the region.

## Audience

*Who is the intended audience for this article?*

Who: Educated adult readers who care about conservation, science, and human interest, National Geographic's typical audience.

*How can you tell? Cite at least TWO specific examples from the text:*

Complex vocabulary: "tranquilizer-reversal drug," "unique physiology" assumes adult literacy.  
Deep historical context about the Pokot-Ilchamus conflict is included with no simplification, assuming readers can handle nuance.

## Purpose

*What is the main purpose of this article?*

Main purpose: Inform readers about the rescue while inspiring action and celebrating community-led conservation.

*What evidence from the text supports your claim about purpose?*

Evidence: The article closes with a "How You Can Help" section pointing to [savegiraffesnow.org](https://www.nationalgeographic.org/savegiraffesnow.org), and ends with the quote "where there is peace, everything is possible" both clearly meant to motivate donors.

## Context

*What larger conversations or issues is this article part of?*

Larger issues: Published in the Earth Day issue (May 2021) during COVID-19, amid global concern over biodiversity loss and climate change-fueled flooding.

*Why does this context matter? How does it make the story significant beyond the immediate event?*

Why it matters: The story shows conservation is inseparable from human peace and climate resilience. Not just about giraffes, it's a model for what cooperation can accomplish globally.

## Rhetorical Appeals

### Pathos (Emotional Appeal)

*Find ONE example of pathos. Quote or describe it, then explain what emotion it creates and why:*

Pathos: "Several animals, adults and calves, died as the waters crept higher." Creates grief and urgency. The mention of calves dying makes the threat feel tragic and real, pushing readers to care.

## Ethos (Credibility)

*How does this article build credibility? Give a specific example:*

Ethos: The article quotes Stephen Chege, identified as "a senior wildlife veterinarian working with the Northern Rangelands Trust," and David O'Connor, president of Save Giraffes.

## Logos (Logic / Reason)

*Describe the logical structure used (cause-effect, problem-solution, etc.) and give an example:*

Logos: Classic problem/solution structure.

Problem: flooding trapped endangered giraffes.

Solution: build a custom barge, safely sedate and transport each giraffe to a predator-proof mainland sanctuary.

Each step is explained logically with specific details for someone with zero prior knowledge.

## Genre

*What genre is this article? (e.g., narrative feature journalism, educational adventure story...)*

Narrative feature journalism

*What genre conventions does this article use? Identify TWO and explain how each serves the audience and purpose:*

Convention 1: Character-centered storytelling, Asiwa becomes the emotional focal point. This makes an abstract conservation issue feel personal and keeps adult readers invested.

Convention 2: Expert quotes from multiple named sources add authority. This serves the purpose of informing while building credibility.

*What can this genre NOT do? What are its constraints?*

Print journalism can't show movement, sound, or real-time tension. A video documentary would capture the crowd's reaction and Asiwa's fear in ways words can't.

## Medium & Design

*How do text and photos work together? What does each element contribute?*

Text & photos: Text provides history, context, and expert quotes. Ami Vitale's dramatic photos show the scale of the operation, conveying what words struggle to express.

*What can this medium NOT do? What would a different medium (e.g., video documentary) do better?*

What this medium can't do: It can't show motion or sound. A video documentary would better capture the moment Asiwa stepped off the barge to applause, or the tension of the tranquilizer dart hitting.

## The Rhetorical Situation (Putting It Together)

*How do exigence, audience, purpose, and context work together in this article? Write 3–5 sentences:*

The flooding crisis gave National Geographic a timely, high-stakes story perfectly suited to their Earth Day issue. The adult audience allows the article to layer conservation science, climate context, and human conflict

history without oversimplifying. The purpose is to inform and inspire action to reverse environmental damage. Context (Earth Day, pandemic, biodiversity crisis) makes this a story that speaks to the moment. Together, these elements like exigence, audience, etc... Turn a single wildlife rescue into a symbol of global significance.

## Reflection

*How effective is this article for its intended audience and purpose? Use at least THREE rhetorical concepts in your answer:*

The article is highly effective. Through pathos, the deaths of calves, Asiwa's near-drowning, readers become emotionally invested before they're even asked to act. Through ethos, citing veterinarians and nonprofit leaders, the article earns trust and authority. The Earth Day context adds urgency, and the "How You Can Help" section converts emotional investment into real action. For adults who may care about nature, this hits every mark.

# Rhetorical Analysis Worksheet

"Giraffe on a Raft" — Kids Article (National Geographic Kids)

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Liam Heary \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Period: \_\_\_\_\_

## Exigence (Why Now?)

*What is the immediate trigger that prompted this article to be written?*

Immediate trigger: Flooding trapped Rothschild's giraffes on a shrinking island, and one giraffe, Asiwa, was completely isolated and in danger of drowning.

*What bigger issues create urgency beyond the immediate event?*

Bigger issues: Giraffes are near threatened; climate change is increasing flooding events; kids need early exposure to why wildlife conservation matters.

## Audience

*Who is the intended audience for this article?*

Elementary/middle school kids, roughly ages 6–14. National Geographic Kids' core readership.

*How can you tell? Cite at least TWO specific examples from the text:*

Playful language and a pun in the headline: "Gir-raft" clearly aimed at making kids laugh. Also, the story is broken into 5 numbered sections with bold headers like "Setting Sail" and "Home Sweet Home" in a simple, picture book structure for young readers.

## Purpose

*What is the main purpose of this article?*

Main purpose: Entertain and educate kids about wildlife conservation through an exciting rescue adventure.

*What evidence from the text supports your claim about purpose?*

Evidence: The article is part of National Geographic's "Planet Possible" campaign, explicitly designed to inspire kids about the environment. Every section title frames the story as an adventure, not a lesson. I enjoyed these quite a bit as a kid & they inspired me to care for the environment.

## Context

*What larger conversations or issues is this article part of?*

Larger issues: Part of Nat Geo Kids' Planet Possible Earth Day series, connecting to global conversations about endangered animals and climate change.

*Why does this context matter? How does it make the story significant beyond the immediate event?*

Why it matters: Framing conservation as a story kids can cheer for plants early environmental values and shows them that real people save real animals in all situations.

## Rhetorical Appeals

### Pathos (Emotional Appeal)

*Find ONE example of pathos. Quote or describe it, then explain what emotion it creates and why:*

Pathos: "Since giraffes can't swim, Asiwa was stuck." Simple but instantly creates worry. Kids immediately picture a giant animal trapped with no way out, pulling them emotionally into the story (while also teaching them simple stuff like giraffes cannot swim)

## Ethos (Credibility)

*How does this article build credibility? Give a specific example:*

Ethos: David O'Connor, president of Save Giraffes Now, is quoted multiple times by name and title. Even for kids, a real expert from a real organization builds trust that this story is true and important.

## Logos (Logic / Reason)

*Describe the logical structure used (cause-effect, problem-solution, etc.) and give an example:*

Logos: Clear problem-solution structure in numbered steps: trapped giraffe, build a raft, convince Asiwa to get onboard, safe voyage to new home. Very easy & logical to follow.

## Genre

*What genre is this article? (e.g., narrative feature journalism, educational adventure story...)*

Educational adventure story / narrative nonfiction for children

*What genre conventions does this article use? Identify TWO and explain how each serves the audience and purpose:*

Convention 1: Numbered steps with bold headers, this gives young readers a clear roadmap through the story, making comprehension easier and keeping them engaged.

Convention 2: Fun language and puns ("Gir-raft"). Lowers the intimidation factor and makes reading feel like entertainment, not schoolwork.

*What can this genre NOT do? What are its constraints?*

Constraints: The simplified format can't include the full historical background (the Pokot-Ilchamus conflict, giraffe population data, veterinary risks) that the adult version covers. Depth is sacrificed for readability.

## Medium & Design

*How do text and photos work together? What does each element contribute?*

Text & photos: Large, stunning wildlife photos grab kids' attention first. Short text blocks sit right next to the photos, so kids visually connect each moment of the story to an image.

*What can this medium NOT do? What would a different medium (e.g., video documentary) do better?*

Print can't show Asiwa moving, the crowd cheering, or the tension in real time. A short animated video or YouTube-style documentary would be far more immersive for young audiences.

## The Rhetorical Situation (Putting It Together)

*How do exigence, audience, purpose, and context work together in this article? Write 3–5 sentences:*

Asiwa's isolation on a flooding island gave Nat Geo Kids a specific, relatable character for young readers to root for. Every writing choice; the puns, the numbered sections, the short sentences, the vivid photos is shaped for the young audience. The purpose of inspiring environmental awareness is achieved through adventure framing, making conservation feel exciting rather than overwhelming. The Planet Possible context invites kids to see themselves as part of a larger movement, giving the story meaning beyond just a cool

animal story. All four elements work together to make conservation feel personal, fun, and urgent for a young reader.

## Reflection

*How effective is this article for its intended audience and purpose? Use at least THREE rhetorical concepts in your answer:*

The article is very effective for its audience. Pathos: Asiwa alone on a shrinking island which immediately creates worry and investment; kids root for her like a storybook character. Ethos: quoting a real expert from a named nonprofit. Logos: the numbered, step-by-step structure helps young readers follow cause and effect without getting lost. .